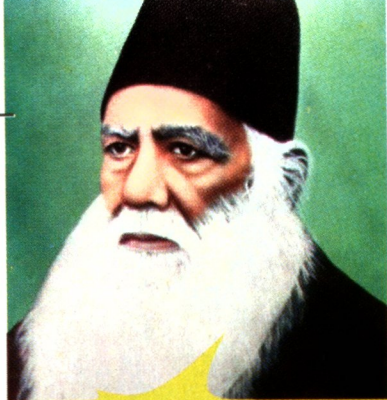




Is it possible that under these circumstances two nations—the Mohammedans and the Hindus—could sit on the same throne and remain equal in power? Most certainly not. —Sir Syed Ahmed Khan

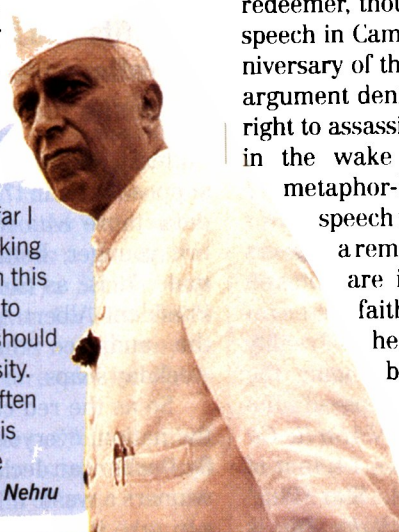
inction between “great speakers and great speeches”, the joy of this book is in the variety of those speakers—the anglicised sophisticate and the homespun rabble-rouser; the wise nationalist and the refined communalist; fantasists of ersatz India and cultural globalists. The proverbial Indian diversity in thought is on full display here. The first part is the prologue to freedom, beginning with Womesh Chandra Bonerjee’s inaugural speech at the opening of Indian National Congress and ending with Nehru’s signature freedom speech which has perhaps the best first line: “Long years ago we made a tryst with destiny, and now the time comes when we shall redeem our pledge, not wholly or in full measure, but very substantially.” Freedom is such a disputed idea here, and there is no unanimity on struggle. The first president of the Congress, as his anglicised name suggests, was an English poodle: “There are no more thoroughly loyal and consistent well-wishers of the British government than myself and the friends around me.”

In this section, we have the best of

old-fashioned rhetoric, some very Indian in its resonance, the rest greatly indebted to Macaulay. Against the 19th-century Sir Syed Ahmed Khan, founder of the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College at Aligarh, we have the 20th-century Savarkar, the apostle of revolutionary Hindutva. Sir Syed was one of the first Muslim intellectuals to emphasise the political incompatibility of Hindu-Muslim co-existence. Beneath his impeccable sophistry on Muslim exceptionalism stirred anger and hate. Still, in the age of Glasgow and other horrors, we would miss the Englishness of a Sir Syed. Would we ever have another Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College? Savarkar, the Hindu nationalist, was a repudiation of the Gandhian cult of passive resistance: “Call it a law of nature or will of God as you like, the hard fact remains that there is no room for absolute non-violence in nature.” But one speech that stands out in the first part for its intellectual passion is Lord Curzon’s address to the Asiatic Society of Bengal in 1900 on the conservation of ancient monuments. It is a masterpiece, and compulsory reading for anyone who has an interest in our cultural heritage.

In the second part of this book, the political speeches lose their rhetorical as well as intellectual sparkle as freedom progresses from the romance of struggle to the banality of power. What saves the pages

I was born a Hindu but I do not know how far I am justified in calling myself one or in speaking on behalf of Hindus. But birth still counts in this country and by right of birth I shall venture to submit to the leaders of the Hindus that it should be their privilege to take the lead in generosity. Generosity is not only good morals, but is often good politics and sound expediency. And it is inconceivable to me that in a free India, the Hindus can ever be powerless. —Jawaharlal Nehru



Art and beauty, and the reverence that is owing to all that has evoked human genius or has inspired human faith, are independent of creeds, and, in so far as they touch the sphere of religion, are embraced by the common religion of all mankind. Viewed from this standpoint, the rock temple of the Brahmans stands on precisely the same footing as the Buddhist Vihara, and the Mohammedan Musjid as the Christian Cathedral. —Lord Curzon

here is the argument that comes from beyond the political arena. The speech writer has taken over, but he is incapable of coming up with even a decent one-liner that has a life beyond the morning headline. Politically, all the usual suspects are represented, up to Advani’s tryst with Jinnah’s ghost in Karachi. The redeemer, though, is Salman Rushdie’s speech in Cambridge on the fourth anniversary of the fatwa. The force of his argument denies the fallacy of faith its right to assassinate imagination. Today, in the wake of his knighthood, as metaphor-killers get re-armed, his speech in King’s College Chapel is a reminder: “Values and morals are independent of religious faith.” In a thematically coherent anthology that celebrates the variations of freedom spanning over a century, it is such sporadic words of dissent that sustain the joy. ■

NEW RELEASE



THE DIANA CHRONICLES
by TINA BROWN
Century
Price: \$18.99
Pages: 481

The subject never became the Queen of England and the author was almost Queen of New York. They were fated to be together and with Tina Brown’s *The Diana Chronicles*, they are. Written 10 years after the death of Diana, princess of Wales, the book is an account of a woman who went from plodding

princess to global celebrity. Calling on a vast array of sources, Brown, part eavesdropper and part archaeologist, has crafted a compelling read which moves easily from Diana’s meltdown to Margaret Thatcher’s iron age, from palace politics to Prince Charles’ private conversations.